Discovery

📊 Help customers manage their inventory with a streamlined, user-friendly integration that meets their core needs.

Phase #1: Discovery

1-1 Define current state experience and user journey

General Workflow Note

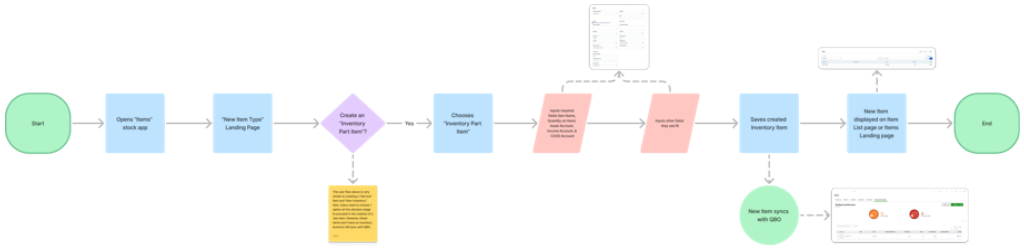
Each user journey described below often follows a sequential process where one deliverable builds upon another, such as estimates leading to sales orders and then invoices. However, it's important to note that each type of deliverable (e.g., estimates, sales orders, invoices) can also be created independently, depending on business needs and specific user scenarios.

Items App Integration and Impact

The items app in Method is central to managing inventory as it integrates with QuickBooks Online (QBO). It allows users to create three types of items: "Service", "Non-Inventory", and "Inventory." Only "Inventory" items are linked with actual inventory levels that are crucial for various operational processes. The items app ensures that any creation or update of items syncs with QBO, impacting inventory levels according to the actions taken within different user journeys. Below we detail how the items app interfaces with other applications and impacts inventory across various scenarios:

User Journey #1: Creating a New Item

- **Process**: Users create items categorized under "Service", "Non-Inventory", or "Inventory."
- **Inventory Impact**: Inventory levels are associated and managed only with "Inventory" items.
- **Integration with QBO**: Newly created items automatically sync, thereby updating inventory levels in QBO.



User Journey #2: Creating an Opportunity

An opportunity in Method represents the initial stage of a potential deal, tracking interactions, progress, and the likelihood of deal closure through various stages of a sales pipeline.

- **Process**: Upon identifying an opportunity, users can add items by selecting the "add items to opportunity" option, which might not be immediately noticeable. Item selection does not display current inventory levels as well.
- **Integration with QBO**: Opportunity itself, once saved, does not sync with QBO.
- **Conversion**: Opportunities can be converted into estimates, sales orders, invoices, or sales receipts on Method. Items from the opportunity carry over into these new documents, yet still without showing current inventory levels in any of these subsequent formats.
- **Inventory Impact**: There is no direct impact on inventory when an opportunity is created or saved. Inventory is only affected once actions are taken on subsequent documents that involve financial transactions (such as invoicing, Bills, and Sales Receipts).

User Journey #3: Creating an Estimate

Before creating an estimate, an opportunity typically arises as a potential business lead. Opportunities go through various stages in a pipeline, and if a customer shows interest in a specific product or service, an estimate can be generated.

- **Process**: Users draft estimates by selecting items and setting quantities.
- **Inventory Overview**: Method does not display inventory levels at this stage, while QBO provides this data.

- **Integration with QBO**: Estimates sync as "pending" with QBO and update to "Accepted" when approved by the customer.
- **Inventory Impact:** No impact on inventory occurs at any stage of the estimate process.

User Journey #4: Creating a Sales Order from an Accepted Estimate

- **Process**: When a sales order is generated from an accepted estimate:
  - **Item Continuity**: Items from the estimate are carried over into the sales order.
- **Inventory Overview**: No inventory levels are shown anywhere on the sales order page.
- **Integration with QBO**: The sales order does not sync with QBO upon saving.
- **Inventory Impact**: There is no change in item quantities on Method or QBO, indicating no immediate inventory impact from creating the sales order.

User Journey #5: Creating an Invoice from a Completed Sales Order

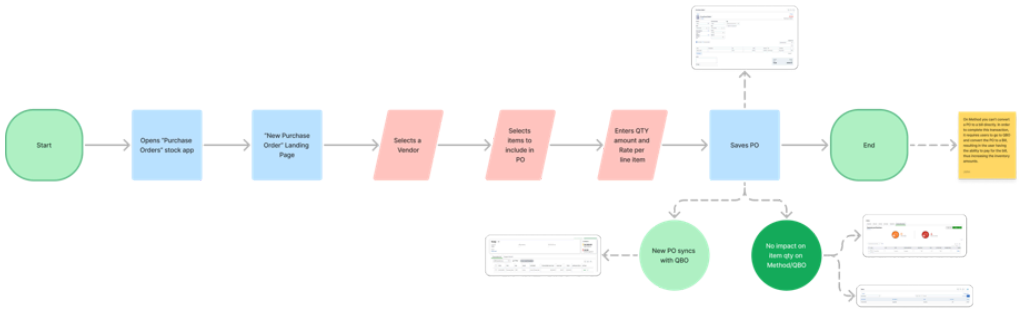
- **Process**: When an invoice is created from a sales order, the process involves:

- **Item Selection**: Users must select which items from the sales order to convert to an invoice. No inventory levels are displayed during this selection.

- **Integration with QBO**: The new invoice syncs with QBO once created.
- **Inventory Impact**: The creation of the invoice impacts item quantities on both Method and QBO.
- **Payment Processing**: After saving the invoice and receiving payment from the customer, the invoice status on QBO is updated to "Paid", while on Method, the invoice shows a balance owing of zero.

User Journey #6: Creating a Purchase Order

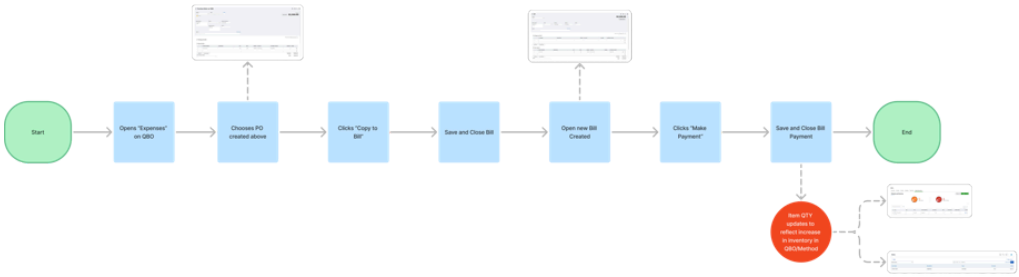
- **Process**: Users generate and save POs.
- **Integration with QBO**: POs sync with QBO.
- **Inventory Impact**: No immediate impact on inventory levels.



User Journey #7: Converting a PO to a Bill on QBO

Direct conversion of a Purchase Order (PO) to a Bill is not possible within Method. This action requires users to access their QuickBooks Online (QBO) account.

- **Process**:
  - **PO to Bill Conversion**: Users must navigate to QBO, where they can convert the latest PO to a Bill.
  - **Payment Processing**: After converting the PO to a Bill, users can proceed to make a payment.
- **Inventory Impact**: Payment of the Bill results in an increase in inventory quantities, reflected in both QBO and Method.



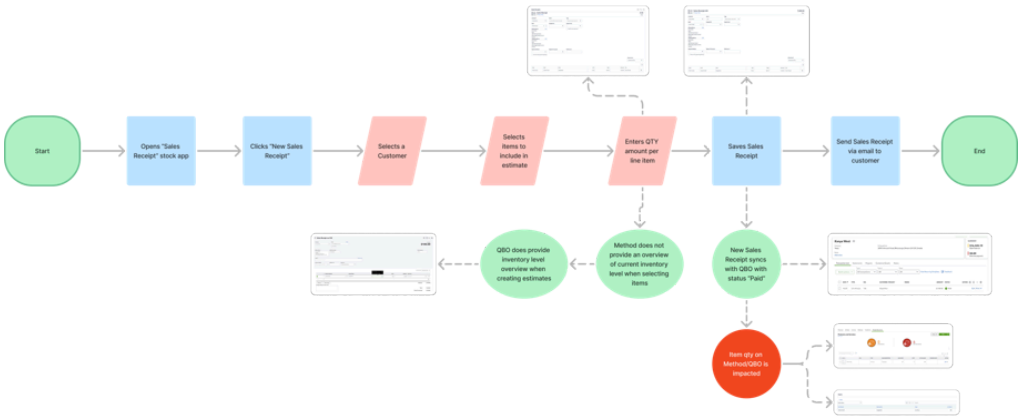
User Journey #8: Creating a Proposal

- **Process**: Proposals are prepared without displaying current inventory levels.
- **Integration with QBO**: Proposals do not sync into QBO.
- **Inventory Impact:** No impact on inventory levels when a proposal is created and accepted.

User Journey #9: Creating a Sales Receipt

A sales receipt in Method is a transaction that records payment received at the time of sale, without any attached terms and conditions, distinguishing it from invoices.

- **Process**: Users can create a sales receipt independently or convert an opportunity into a sales receipt.
- **Inventory Overview:** When selecting items and quantities for the sales receipt, no inventory levels are displayed on Method, although QBO does provide this information.
- **Integration with QBO:** The sales receipt syncs with QBO upon saving.
- **Inventory Impact:** Upon saving, item quantity is impacted on both Method and QBO, reflecting a decrease in inventory due to the sale.



[Sales Management Whiteboard]

Inventory Impact Summary

This section outlines which specific user journeys above result in an impact on item inventory levels, providing a clear overview for stakeholders to understand where and how inventory changes occur within the Method in conjunction with QuickBooks Online.

- **User Journey #4: Creating an Invoice from a Completed Sales Order**
  - **Impact**: Significantly impacts inventory. The creation of an invoice decreases item quantities in both Method and QBO. This change occurs once the invoice is created and synced with QBO.
- **User Journey #6: Converting a PO to a Bill on QBO**

- **Impact**: Results in an increase in inventory quantities. This occurs after a PO is converted to a Bill in QBO and the bill is paid, reflecting updated inventory levels in both QBO and Method.

- **User Journey #9: Creating a Sales Receipt**
  - **Process**: Directly decreases inventory levels at the time of sale, immediately syncing this change with QBO as the sales receipt is saved.

Additionally, any manual updates made to item quantities within the Items App on Method will trigger corresponding inventory updates on QBO, and vice versa. This ensures that inventory levels remain consistent across both platforms, providing real-time accuracy and control over stock management.

Current State Experience

Based on the detailed analysis of the various user journeys associated with the current inventory management system in Method, we gain several key insights about the current state experience for Method users:

1. **Lack of Real-Time Inventory Data in Method**:
   - One of the most significant gaps identified is the absence of real-time inventory levels across multiple stages of the user journey. Whether creating an estimate, an opportunity, a sales order, or processing a sales receipt, users do not have visibility into current inventory levels within Method itself, although QBO does provide this information in some contexts. This can lead to challenges in managing inventory effectively and may result in errors or inefficiencies.
2. **Inventory Impact Only at Specific Points**:
   - Inventory levels are only impacted by actions that involve financial transactions, such as invoicing and sales receipts, or when a PO is converted to a bill in QBO. Other preparatory or intermediary steps, such as estimates and opportunities, do not affect inventory until they are converted into these financially impactful documents.
3. **Complex Navigation and Usability Issues**:
   - The user experience can be complex and potentially confusing, particularly for new users or those not familiar with the Method interface.